employees tested and perfected all of these poisons. Other ideas which were explored and rejected included planting an exotic seashell rigged to explode in the area where Castro was going skin diving, and presenting him with a contaminated diving suit.[28]

To carry out these murder attempts, the CIA cultivated ties with the U.S. gambling syndicate that operated in Cuba, offering $150,000 for a successful assassination, starting in August 1960.[29] The CIA's syndicate contacts were involved in several different attempts to kill Castro with poison pills from 1960–63. Apparently Castro's internal security forces were able to foil some of these plots.[30]

As U.S. opposition to Castro cemented, his popularity in Cuba remained strong. U.S. policymakers needed to consider, Ambassador Bonsal cautioned, the "continued emotional attachment to Fidel Castro as national symbol by bulk of the Cuban people," as well as "the continued belief by virtually all Cubans in the need for social and economic changes, embodied to date only in Castro's revolutionary program."[31]

Assistant Secretary of State for Inter-American Affairs' Special Assistant Hill mentioned with concern "the impact that real honesty, especially at the working level, has made on the people" and "the fact that a great bulk of the Cubans … have awakened enthusiastically to the need for social and economic reform."[32] Yet the U.S. goal, he insisted, was precisely the opposite: "we must insure that a successor government comports itself in our interests."[33]

U.S. officials continued to publicly insist on their non-interventionist stance, even as the real policy progressed to invasion, terrorism, and assassination plots. They feigned pained innocence when Castro's charges accurately described what they were doing. U.S. President Eisenhower publicly decried "the tendency of Cuban Government spokesmen, including Prime Minister Castro, to create the illusion of aggressive acts and conspiratorial activities aimed at the Cuban Government and attributed to United States officials or agencies."[34] While denouncing Cuban paranoia about U.S. intentions and activities,